XCITY · URBAN DESIGN AND AI PLANNING CALLS

DESIGN PRACTICE CALL

Redesigning a city for the silicon age.

San Juan, Argentina · a call for qualifications, then design by a shortlist

Free registration | Two stages | 1,656 km²

Competition brief



COMPETITION CONDITIONS

CONTENTS

01 Introduction
02 The idea
03 Theme and challenge
04 The site
05 Given conditions
06 Designing with care
07 Five urban systems
08 Scope: four layers
09 The whole site
10 Phase one
11 Key issues
12 Who can apply
13 Two stages
14 What to submit
15 How the jury assesses
16 Honorarium and further work
17 Key dates
18 Free registration and the jury
19 Publicity and terms
20 Contact and data

01 · INTRODUCTION

TWO CALLS, ONE SITE

XCITY plans a new city in San Juan province, Argentina: 1,656 km² of real land, with energy and compute as its economic base.

This call looks for urban design and planning practices able to propose a city of real spatial quality, and to take it further. It runs beside the Open Agent Call on the same site; the two share the site and its conditions and are reviewed and ranked separately.

What XCITY wants from this call

A spatial framework for the whole site, a phase-one city that can run on its own, and representative urban design that a team can carry into further work.

What it is not

Not a single building, a branding exercise or a picture of the future. Qualifications come first; no practice carries design work before its terms are known.



02 · THE IDEA

FROM CARBON TO SILICON

For two hundred years cities rested on fossil energy and human labour: roads, housing and services formed around work and the commute.

Power → compute → AI agents → robots. A new set of production infrastructure.

As agents take part in work and decisions and robots take on more execution, production and maintenance, the way a city is organised can change. San Juan, with sun, land and real limits, is a place to test it.

03 · THEME AND CHALLENGE

A CITY THAT HOLDS TOGETHER

Neither a blank sheet nor a brief that only asks for the look of the future: the design has to hold energy, production, daily life and the site's real constraints together.

GUIDING QUESTION

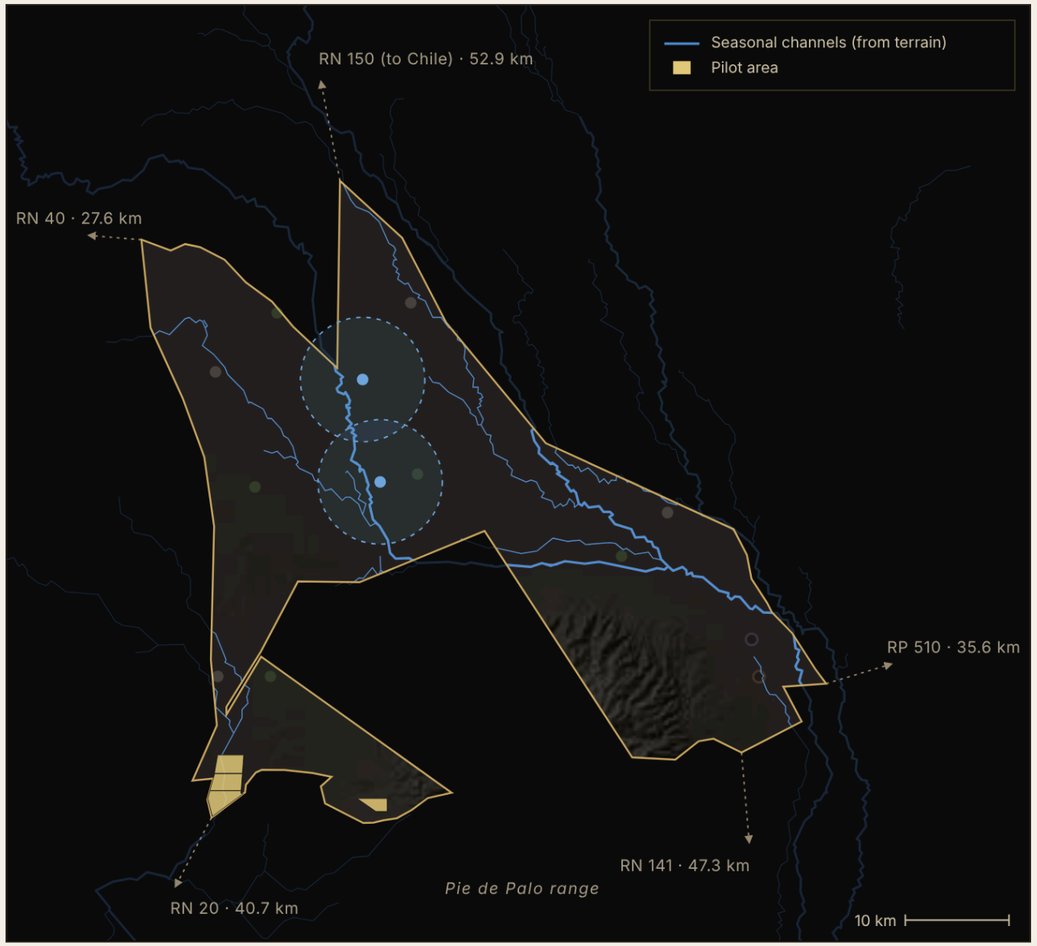
When energy, compute, agents and robots become the base of production, how should a new city's structure, uses and public life be designed?

- How a city built on solar power and compute stands up on dry, seismic, windy land
- How an economy with few jobs supports a city with a full public life
- How people, autonomous vehicles and robots share urban space

04 · THE SITE

1,656 KM² OF REAL LAND

Site	1,656 km² of continuous land, east of the Andes in San Juan province
Two parts	A large western piece, with the Pie de Palo range and a flat eastern wing, and a smaller piece to the south-west with the pilot area
Terrain	Elevation 606–2,658 m; slope < 2% on 1,183 km²; the Pie de Palo range in the south-east
Flood	503 km² flood-sensitive along seasonal channels
Roads	No national or provincial road on site. RN 40 ≈ 27.6 km · RP 510 ≈ 35.6 km · RN 20 ≈ 40.7 km



Figures from the organiser's site data. The full site package goes to the shortlisted teams.

05 · GIVEN CONDITIONS

WHAT IS ALREADY THERE

A

Agrivoltaic fields 01–03

13.9 km². Under the arrays a symbiotic system runs: jojoba, rosemary, forage cactus and alpaca. Its layout is fixed.

B

Living quarter, phase 1

2.48 km² beside the agrivoltaic fields: the city's first neighbourhood. Only its outline is published.

C

Compute as POD clusters

XCITY's modular data centres are placed as clusters near the solar connection points; layout, service roads, waste heat and buffers are for the design.

The pilot area (A + B) is not open to design. A scheme meets it; it does not redraw it.

06 · SITE CONSIDERATIONS

DESIGN WITH CARE

1

Water

One water balance for every use; water rights are not supplied. State what you assume and what stops first in a shortage.

2

Earthquakes

Among Argentina's most seismic provinces; the INPRES-CIRSOC 103 code family applies.

3

The Zonda

A dry, hot, dusty downslope wind. Block it, channel it, or step aside, and say which.

4

Dry channels

Dry most of the year, flooding within minutes. No permanent construction on a channel.

5

Dark sky

San Juan hosts observatories: give a night-lighting strategy.

6

No road

The access corridor is itself phase-one construction work.

Phase one stands on its own: water, power, services, access and public life complete at its own scale, even if nothing after it is built.

07 · FIVE URBAN SYSTEMS

FIVE SYSTEMS, ONE CITY

System	Planning weight	Where it tends to go
Energy + compute	~60%	Gentle, flood-free ground near water and cooling, grid and fibre; buffered from housing
Agri-production	~30%	The fixed agrivoltaic system plus outer rings of tall crops (pistachio, olive, vine) placed by the scheme
Living and public life	~5%	Near infrastructure and reliable water; clustered settlements and estates, mix and place set by the scheme
Industry + automation	~3%	Settlement industry in every phase; gateway industry on the eastern wing in a later phase
Trade and port of entry	~2%	Eastern wing, facing inland and the Atlantic route; land and access held from phase one

Weights show emphasis in planning, not exclusive land shares. Indicative positions are in the site package; they are a direction, not a boundary.

08 · SCOPE

FOUR LAYERS, ONE PLAN

Layer	Extent	Decides	Depth
1 · The whole site	All 1,656 km²	Where to protect, produce and build; centres, corridors, capacity and phasing	Districts and networks: real position, size, link and basis
2 · Phase one	Drawn and argued by the team	Where the city starts and how it runs on its own	Layout, services, utilities, first works and expansion
3 · Urban design zoom-in	Chosen by the team, no fixed area	How the layout becomes streets, blocks and public space	Blocks, massing, heights, public realm, interfaces, guidelines
4 · Key issues	Placed in layers 1–3, with their phase	How people and machines actually use the space	Plans, sections, flows and operating scenarios

Not suitable: a scheme that designs one district well and leaves the rest of the site as a colour diagram; key issues that are not placed in the plan above them.

09 · THE WHOLE SITE

TEN THINGS TO DECIDE

01
Suitability: protect, limit, build

02
Spatial structure: one city or settlements, centres, growth

03
Land-use framework, buffers and reserves

04
Population, jobs and capacity by district

05
Ecology, water and open space

06
Transport, logistics and the human–machine system

07
Water and utilities

08
Energy, compute and communications

09
Public services and centres

10
Phasing, reserves and order of works

Depth: position, size, link and basis; buildings as capacity and form principles. Items may share drawings, but each must be findable. Compare at least two ways to start the city and say why one is chosen.

10 · PHASE ONE

A CITY THAT RUNS FROM DAY ONE

Phase one sets out housing, jobs, schools, clinics and shops, production and maintenance, on-site logistics, access, energy, water, wastewater reuse, waste and emergency services, and shows they work without later phases.

Choose an area of the phase-one city to take to urban-design depth: no fixed size, but enough to test a centre, typical housing and a production or infrastructure edge. Later phases are triggered by conditions that can be observed, not by dates.

Reference scenario for phase one

Population	50,000
Jobs	20,000
Compute load	200 MW
Solar	1–3 GW

Every team works to the same scenario. Water for it is not secured: state the source you assume. Long-term size is for the scheme to argue.

11 · KEY ISSUES

THREE IN DEPTH, EIGHT IN PRINCIPLE

Six key issues · choose three to develop in depth

- Arrival into the city
- Housing community and prototypes
- A quiet place at the foot of the mountain
- Logistics hub and trade gateway
- Compute campus and its waste heat
- Streets shared with driverless vehicles

In depth: site plan, sections, flows, building or space prototype, operation.

Five strategic issues

- Drone landing and docking
- Solar agriculture and the city edge
- Seasonal river parks
- Places for art and culture
- Public space in heat, sun and wind

The three key issues not chosen join these five: position in the plan, principles, a typical response.

Each issue is placed in the whole-site plan and phase one, with its phase. Related issues may share a site and drawings.

12 · ELIGIBILITY

WHO CAN APPLY

Professional teams able to carry a city plan from structure to streets.

Individuals and students

Welcome in the Open Agent Call, which needs no registered practice.

Requirements

- Led by a legally constituted practice in urban design, planning, landscape architecture or architecture
- The lead has completed or led a masterplan, new district or new town of 100 ha or more in the last fifteen years
- The team covers urban design, landscape and ecology, energy and infrastructure, and water
- A firm may lead or join one team only; consortia are welcome
- No Argentine partner is needed; XCITY arranges local collaboration for the selected team
- Organiser staff, jury members and their immediate families may not take part

13 · PROCEDURE

TWO STAGES

STAGE 1

Qualifications

One PDF, up to 20 pages and 20 MB, form included; English or Chinese:

- The application form, signed (page 1)
- Practice profile (up to 3 pages)
- Key people (up to 4 pages)
- Three to five reference projects (up to 2 pages each)
- Approach statement (up to 2 pages): your reading of the site's key issues and how you would work. No design for this site
- Attached separately, not counted: proof of registration; conflict-of-interest declaration

STAGE 2

Design, by the shortlist

Shortlisted teams receive the full site package, an online briefing and a written question period, and design the four layers. Each compliant entry receives an honorarium.

SELECTION

Review and selection

Shortlisted teams present online to the jury. Selected teams move to further work with XCITY.

14 · SUBMISSION REQUIREMENTS

WHAT TO SUBMIT

1
Six A0 boards
Landscape; the whole site, phase one, the zoom-in and the key issues

2
A3 report
Up to 60 pages including appendices, with an index from each requirement to its drawing

3
Design statement
Up to 800 words: concept, response to the site, approach

4
Preview image
One image for the website and publicity

5
Data
Metrics workbook (XLSX: units, scope, basis) and CAD / GIS files

6
Language and anonymity
English; boards carry no practice name or logo

Stage two. Video and physical models are optional. More pages or media earn no marks. File formats, size limits, naming and the upload link are published with the formal rules.

15 · EVALUATION CRITERIA

STAGE TWO · SCHEME REVIEW

Criterion	What the review looks for
Site reading and spatial structure	Would the plan be different on another site? Do water, slope, wind, quakes and the pilot area shape where the city goes and how it grows?
Systems and resources	Do water, energy, compute, population and services support each other, with a shortage scenario that changes the plan?
Urban and spatial quality	Are streets, blocks, centres and public spaces worth living in, in this climate, for different people?
Phasing and delivery	Can phase one be built and run on its own; are first works, dependencies and triggers credible?
Interfaces and readiness for further work	Are the interfaces between disciplines clear? Is the scheme ready to be taken further? Are the questions still to be verified named?
Presentation and communication	Are complex ideas clear, consistent between drawings, figures and text?

Compliance is checked before scoring. The weight of each criterion is published with the formal rules.

16 · PRIZES

HONORARIUM AND FURTHER WORK

Honorarium	Every shortlisted team that delivers a compliant stage-two entry
Further work	Selected teams move to further work with XCITY under a separate agreement
Amounts and numbers	Published with the formal rules: the honorarium, the size of the shortlist and the number selected

Terms are known before any design starts.



17 · COMPETITION SCHEDULE

KEY DATES

- **LAUNCH** _____
- **QUALIFICATIONS DEADLINE** _____
- **SHORTLIST ANNOUNCED** _____
- **ONLINE BRIEFING** _____
- **MID-TERM EXCHANGE (NOT SCORED)** _____
- **STAGE-TWO SUBMISSION** _____
- **PRESENTATIONS AND JURY** _____
- **RESULTS** _____

Dates are published with the formal rules and announced on the call's web page.

18 · REGISTRATION AND JURY

REGISTRATION + JURY

Free registration

There is no fee to apply or to take part.

For now this is an expression of interest: email competition@xcity.ai. Formal applications open once the fees and the schedule are published with the formal rules; registered practices are notified.

Jury process

A jury of qualified experts in planning, architecture, landscape and energy infrastructure reviews the entries against the published criteria. Names and affiliations are published with the formal rules.

Do not contact jury members about the call; doing so may lead to disqualification.

19 · PUBLICITY AND TERMS

PUBLICITY + TERMS

Publicity and exhibition

Shortlisted and selected work may be shown on XCITY's website, in exhibitions and publications. Make sure every image, map and AI-generated element can legally be published.

Conduct

- Work must be original and must not infringe the rights of others
- AI tools may be used; disclose how, and the team stays responsible for the result
- No claim of official approval, permit or statutory status
- Every explanation affecting the task, eligibility or review is published in writing, the same for every applicant; an online check of a practice's credentials gives no individual explanation
- Authorship, publication rights and intellectual property: published with the formal rules

20 · CONTACT AND DATA

CONTACT + DATA

Questions

Email with the subject line XCITY - Design Practice Call - Question.

competition@xcity.ai

This brief is a preview. Once the formal rules are published, they govern.

Data

- Stage 1: this brief and the application form (Word), on the call's web page
- Stage 2: the full site package (boundaries, pilot area, terrain, channels, roads, indicative systems), an online briefing and written answers, for the shortlisted teams
- Not supplied: cadastre, grid capacity, water rights, climate series